

BAD DATA

Bad data is not one problem, it is four.

How to decide with data when the data is bad.

AND THE CONSEQUENCE

And the most dangerous one is the number that looks right and measures something else.

THE CASCADE

Waiting for the data to improve is not deciding.

WHAT YOU SEE

The number is unconvincing, so you ask for a review of the dataset.

THE MECHANISM

The review comes back better, never perfect, and you ask for another.

THE CONSEQUENCE

The quarter closes, and the decision was made by inertia.

Not deciding is also a decision. Only it was made by whoever was not in the room.

THE FORK

What exactly is wrong with that data?

WHAT IS WRONG

01

Is the value off?

that is measurement, fix it with the people on the ground

02

Does it arrive too late?

that is cadence, swap it for a leading indicator

03

Does it measure something else?

that is definition, and that is the dangerous defect

Disconnected data is the only one that fools you confidently. The others at least warn you.

THE METHOD

The Four Defects.

01 **WRONG**

the measurement is off, check on the ground before discarding it

02 **INCOMPLETE**

a piece is missing, decide on the piece you have and name the hole

03 **LATE**

arrives too late to correct, swap it for something that leads

04 **DISCONNECTED**

measures something else, the worst because it looks reliable

Naming the defect already solves half. The other half is deciding anyway.

WHAT TO ASK, IN ORDER

Four questions to qualify the number.

01 • WRONG

Who collects this, and how?

fifteen minutes with that person settles a lot of doubt

02 • INCOMPLETE

What is missing from the dataset?

naming the hole lets you decide in spite of it

03 • LATE

When does this number arrive?

if it arrives after the fix is possible, it is history

04 •
DISCONNECTED

Does it measure what we want to change?

if it does not, it is noise wearing the look of rigor

TWO MODELS

Two ways to handle imperfect data.

THE COMMON MODEL

Waiting for better

Sends the dataset back for review

Debates methodology in a committee

Postpones the decision until confident

Decides late, and by inertia

THE DESIGNED MODEL

Qualify and decide

Names the specific defect

Validates in fifteen minutes on the ground

Decides on the piece that exists

Sets the date to revisit with better data

MISTAKE AND CONSEQUENCE

Three habits with bad data.

01 Treating every defect as unreliability.

→ four different problems with one single answer.

02 Never talking to whoever collects it.

→ most of the doubt dies in fifteen minutes of conversation.

03 Accepting the pretty number without checking what it measures.

→ the disconnected one survives because nobody questions what looks good.

The metric that never gets worse is usually the one measuring the wrong thing.

THE CHAIN

The frontline test.

01

Take the number to whoever runs the process.



02

Ask whether it matches their day.



03

If the answer comes with a crooked smile, you found the defect.



WHERE LEADERSHIP STEPS IN

Fifteen minutes on the ground beat three weeks of dataset review.

RUN IT THIS WAY NEXT TIME

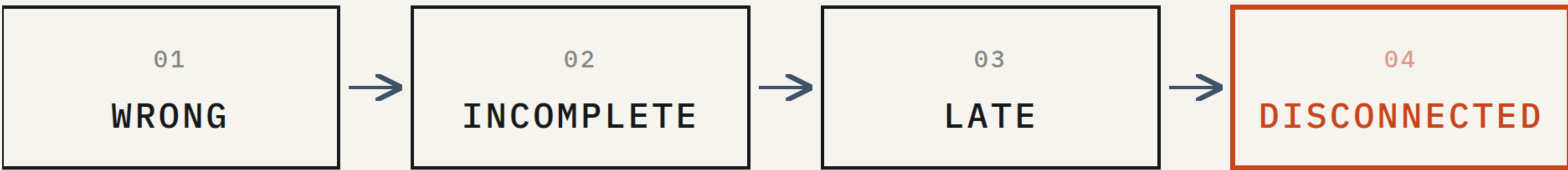
Three moves at the next numbers meeting.

		
STEP 01	STEP 02	STEP 03
Classify the defect before discussing the decision.	Validate with the operators, in the same week.	Decide on the reliable piece and set the review.
wrong, incomplete, late or disconnected	a short conversation, no presentation	with a date, so it does not become an eternal decision

Start with the metric that looks too good. That is where the defect usually lives.

THE MODEL THAT STICKS

The Four Defects, in the order that matters.



The worst data is not the wrong number. It is the one that looks right.

SAVE THIS FOR LATER

in the next meeting where someone asks for another dataset review.

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